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Chapter 6

Activism in the Digital Age: Social Movements Analysis Using User- Generated Content in Social Media

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ABSTRACT

Social movements have been transformed in the last decade by social networks, where the dynamics of the social protests have evolved and have been structured and viralized through social media. They are no longer just conversations between activists that stay on social platforms. The cyberactivism that takes place on Twitter or Instagram can also play a significant role in general society by influencing government decision making or shaping the relationships between citizens. In this chapter, the authors explore the main activist movements that took place in social media in the last decade: Occupy, BlackLivesMatter, and MeToo. The proposed approach used in this study facilitates the comparison of each movement while focusing on the user-generated content in social media. This study suggests the presence of four major categories to frame the content generated by the activists. The chapter concludes with the identification of three different approaches to the research of a future research agenda that should be considered for the study of the social movements from the UGC theory framework.

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Furthermore, as stated in recent research (Saura et al., 2021), in the digital ecosystem, data would be the new currency for businesses and companies, as the analysis and use of UGD can predict user behavior and analyze their actions.

Limitations and Future Research

The limitations of the present study are related to the number of cases selected in the study, the sample analyzed in each case and the types of analysis used to analyze the data. In terms of future research objectives, the research propositions described above should be taken into account as starting points to establish new directions and lines of research focused on gaining a better understanding of the social movements in social media based on the analysis of UGC.

Furthermore, the categorical classification of the tweets, as well as the exploratory selection, can be taken into account as a limitation, since other studies have shown statistical significance and additional quantitative analysis in similar approaches. In the future, researchers can use these results to propose new constructs or variables for quantitative models, as well as follow the research proposals revealed in the present study.

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KEY TERMS AND DEFINITIONS

Social Movements: sustained and organized collective actions to effect change in institutions by citizens or members of institutions who are excluded from routine decision-making (Amenta & Polletta, 2019).

Cyberactivism: the use of electronic communication technologies, such as social media, for various forms of activism to enable faster communications by citizen movements and the delivery of local information to a large audience (Sandoval-Almazan & Gil-Garcia, 2014).

Hashtag Activism: discursive protest on social media united through a hashtagged word, phrase or sentence (Yang, 2016).

User-Generated Content: material that comes from standard users who voluntarily create and publish different data, information and content, which is subsequently published and may be of interest to others (Krumm et al., 2008).

Case Study: research methodology based on an empirical inquiry that investigates a contemporary phenomenon in depth and within its real-world context (Yin, 2014).

Content Analysis: research methodology that comprises techniques for reducing texts to a unit-by-variable matrix and analyzing that matrix quantitatively to test hypotheses (Kohlbacher, 2006).